

14. Documentation Phrases & Sentence Starters

Ready-to-use professional language for writing objective observation notes.

Copy or adapt these sentence starters directly into your observation notes. Fill in the bracketed information with specific, accurate details.

Opening an Observation Note	
During [activity/routine] on [date], [child's initials] ____	Over the past [X days/weeks], staff have observed that ____
On [date] at [time] during [activity], the following was observed: ____	This observation was recorded by [initials] on [date] at [time] in [location]. ____
During a [X-minute] observation of [routine], [child's initials] ____	

Describing Frequency & Duration	
This occurred ____ times during the ____ minute observation.	The behavior lasted approximately ____ minutes each time.
Staff have observed this pattern on ____ out of the past ____ school days.	This was the ____ time this week this occurred during [routine].
The child remained [in this state] for approximately ____ minutes before ____	Staff documented ____ separate incidents between [date] and [date].

Describing What Helped	
The child calmed within ____ minutes when ____	The child completed the task after [support] was provided.
When given [strategy], the child [response].	The child responded well to [adult] using a [calm/quiet/warm] voice.
With a visual schedule in place, the child [response].	When offered a choice between ____ and ____, the child ____
After a [X-minute] movement break, the child ____	

Describing What Did Not Help	
Verbal redirection alone did not result in ____	The child did not respond to [strategy] on this occasion.
Repeated verbal prompting did not change the behavior.	The behavior continued despite [support tried].
The child's distress did not decrease when [approach] was used.	

Closing an Observation Note	
Follow-up: [action planned]	This observation will be shared with [family/team] on [date].
Pattern has been noted across [X] observations. Referral is being considered.	Staff will continue to document this pattern and review on [date].
This note has been reviewed by [supervisor initials] on [date].	Observation documented by [initials]. Record stored in [location].

A note on professional responsibility: These word banks are a starting point, not a shortcut. The best documentation is specific, accurate, and grounded in direct observation. Before sharing any observation with a family, re-read it and ask: Does this describe what I actually saw and heard? Does it treat this child and family with dignity? Could I stand behind this professionally? If the answer to all three is yes — it's ready to share.